

A calm guide to all this, and 100 ways to make it better.

Read the guide first — it explains the whole thing in plain words. Then pick from 100 concrete moves, grouped in tens and tagged by how much effort each takes. You do not have to do them in order. You do not have to do them all.

Prepared 2026-07-25 · a synthesis from inside the project · status_authority:
NONE (this is advice, not accepted truth)

HOW TO READ THIS WITHOUT GETTING OVERWHELMED

- **Start with the guide (Part 1).** If a word is new, it's in the glossary right there.
- **If you only have five minutes,** read the "If you only do five things" box. That's enough.
- **The 100 are a menu, not a to-do list.** Ten themes, ten each. Skim the theme titles, dive only where you feel pull.
- **Every move has an effort tag** — Quick, Medium, or Deep — so you can match your energy to the day.
- **Nothing here is urgent except one thing,** and it's already flagged on the front door of the Lab. The rest can wait for a fresh head.

What all this actually is

You're building two connected things. The first is a **way of working with AI honestly** — a lab where you and several AI "seats" collaborate, and where the system is built to always show **what's been proven** versus **what's only been claimed**. The second is a **vision**: a commons for creative work, where who-made-what is proven by cryptography and social recognition instead of by lawyers, platforms, or money.

Here's the thing worth being proud of: the lab's real invention isn't the app or the economy or the creatures. It's the **honesty machinery** — a discipline that keeps its own mistakes visible and refuses to let a nice-sounding claim pass as a fact. Most people hide their cracks. You made showing them the whole point.

THE WORDS, IN PLAIN LANGUAGE

The Lab Your main, careful project. What's on its "main" line is treated as accepted and real.

The Sandbox A separate, messier playground where wild ideas can be tried and broken without risking the Lab.

Honesty machinery The habits that keep the project truthful: evidence tags, a mistakes log, "not trusted until proven."

Evidence tiers Labels on every claim: proven-in-code, actually-run, someone-said-so, or can't-be-checked.

status_authority: NONE A stamp meaning "this is a draft/opinion, not official." Stops good writing from pretending to be truth.

The emergency stop A loud note at the front of the Lab saying serious work is paused until one specific hole is decided.

The commons The long-term dream: proof of authorship for art, held by you, not for sale, seceded from finance.

A seat One AI (Claude, Grok, Codex, Fable...) doing work in the project. They share one account, so none is truly independent.

The thesis The open question we just shipped for every model to test: is the project deeply structured ("isomorphism") or just talking to itself ("turtles")?

Where you are right now

DONE

The two vision artifacts, the emergency stop, and the honest Noted assessment are all merged and live on the Lab's main line.

LIVE

The "Turtles or Isomorphism?" thesis is public in the Sandbox (PR #6), ready for every model you can reach to test.

LIVE

Noted is genuinely built — ~30,000 lines, a real build, 18 studios. It's on the real side of the line.

OPEN

The one real hole: the Agent's "Pop out" / "Open tab" buttons can reach your stored notes. It's flagged, not fixed — your decision.

OPEN

PR #122 (the security fix branch) is held on purpose, waiting for that decision and a fresh head.

IF YOU ONLY DO FIVE THINGS

1. **Decide the pop-out hole** — remove the two buttons, move the Agent to its own address, or disclose it. This lifts the emergency stop. (#1)
2. **Make one declared promise actually enforced** — build the "no-sale" scanner the spec already demands, so a headline claim becomes true, not just written. (#3)
3. **Narrow Noted to its three real studios** (Prompts, Canvas, Projects) so a stranger isn't handed eighteen doors. (#31)
4. **Put one real artist + one real artwork** through the commons idea — that single external test is what turns "turtles" into "isomorphism." (#53, #62)
5. **Get one genuinely outside reviewer** — a person who isn't you — to try to break it. It's the one thing the whole method can't do for itself. (#21)

PART 2 — THE JOURNEY, BRIEFLY

How we got here

We started with a routine health-check of your tools, and you asked to look deeper. That turned into a real tour: I traced the Lab from its genesis commit, we built two artifacts that carry your intent honestly, we made the security hole a visible emergency stop instead of a buried footnote, and we shipped a falsifiable thesis about whether the whole project's self-similarity is a strength

or a trap. Along the way we hardened your workflow so you can't act in the wrong folder by accident.

The honest through-line: **the project is real and its values are genuinely built into it, not just written down** — and its recurring weakness is that it **declares** things faster than it **enforces** them. Almost every move below is a way to close that one gap, in one corner of the project or another.

PART 3 — THE 100 MOVES

A menu, grouped in tens

QUICK an afternoon

MEDIUM a few sessions

DEEP a real project

01 · 1-10 Make what's declared actually true

The project's #1 pattern: promises written but not enforced. Close the gap.

1 **Decide the pop-out hole** — remove the buttons, separate origin, or disclose.

MEDIUM

It's the current emergency stop. Nothing else in the security arc moves until you choose.

2 **Implement the fix and make ods : sec003 go green.**

MEDIUM

Turn the deliberately-failing test into a passing one — proof, not intention.

3 **Build the forbidden-surface scanner the spec already mandates.**

DEEP

"STRICT NO SALE" is asserted everywhere with zero enforcement. This makes the headline claim real.

4 **Add a runtime test that rejects any no-sale / no-transfer surface.**

MEDIUM

A capability that can't exist beats a promise not to use it.

5 **Quarantine or delete the legacy Wallet / NEX / local-key paths.**

MEDIUM

Dead financial surfaces contradict the vision and invite the exact bug you fear.

6 **Fix CARD-11: stop storing provider keys in plain text at rest.**

MEDIUM

A standing red that undercuts every "private by default" claim.

7 **Wire each closed security test into an automatic gate.**

QUICK

Manual checks rot. If it isn't in CI, assume it isn't run.

8 **Re-probe the shipped dist / build, not just the dev server.**

MEDIUM

"dist parity UNKNOWN" means you don't yet know the real product is safe.

9 **Label every declared "MUST" as enforced or not-yet-enforced.**

QUICK

Honest bookkeeping that instantly shows the size of the gap.

10 **Add a per-release "declared vs enforced" checklist.**

QUICK

No privacy claim ships ahead of the mechanism that backs it.

02 · 11-20 Keep the honesty machinery from becoming ritual

Your best asset. Protect it from turning into paperwork with no teeth.

- 11 **Run a periodic "is this gate still real?" audit.** MEDIUM
A green check that no longer tests anything is worse than a red one.
- 12 **Track the declared → enforced conversion rate over time.** MEDIUM
One number that tells you if the project is closing its gap or widening it.
- 13 **Rotate a "red seat" whose only job is to make the machinery lie.** MEDIUM
Adversarial pressure keeps honesty from drifting into self-congratulation.
- 14 **Keep the Whoopsie (mistakes) log on the front door.** QUICK
Visible mistakes are the trust signal. Buried ones are just shame.
- 15 **Cap the process-doc-to-working-code ratio.** QUICK
When docs outpace code, pause and build. You've been doc-heavy.
- 16 **Define exactly what promotes something out of status_authority: NONE.** MEDIUM
If nothing ever leaves NONE, the stamp is decoration.
- 17 **Audit reports for "eloquence closing a red."** QUICK
A well-written paragraph must never be allowed to clear a real failure.
- 18 **Flag every "no such thing exists" claim for a go-and-look check.** QUICK
The T-01b lesson: negative-existence claims are the only kind you can't re-check by reading.
- 19 **Timebox audits-of-audits; declare diminishing returns out loud.** QUICK
Rigor can recurse forever. Naming "enough" is part of the rigor.
- 20 **Keep one always-current "what's actually true today" file at root.** QUICK
Generalize the emergency-stop pattern into a permanent honest snapshot.

03 · 21–30 Break the closed loop (independence)

One account, one human, AI witnesses only. The method can catch errors but can't create independence. This is the deepest limit.

21 **Recruit one genuinely external human reviewer.** MEDIUM
Not a model, not your account. The single highest-value thing you can't do alone.

22 **Get a model run by someone else, on their machine, to attack it.** MEDIUM
Different hands break the same-account illusion of independence.

23 **Never call same-account model agreement "corroboration."** QUICK
You already wrote this rule. Enforce it everywhere, out loud.

24 **Keep a "why not to trust this" page a stranger reads first.** QUICK
Leading with your own limits is disarming and rare.

25 **Invite a hostile outsider to attack the Lab; publish it unedited.** MEDIUM
The unedited part is what makes it believable.

26 **Open a public "find a declared/enforced gap" challenge.** MEDIUM
Crowd-source the exact audit you most need, on your own terms.

27 **Separate "operator" from "reviewer" roles even within your own work.** QUICK
On the record, distinct hats reduce the confusion of being both.

28 **Get the cryptography checked by an independent cryptographer.** DEEP
The cage's post-quantum claims deserve a real outside eye.

29 **Everywhere, distinguish "verified by a seat in the loop" from "by an outside witness."** QUICK
Same words, very different weight. Name which one you have.

30 **Treat the thesis responses from others' models as your first independence probe.** QUICK
You just shipped the instrument — the responses are real outside signal.

04 · 31–40 Ship the narrow real core (Noted)

Noted is genuinely built. Focus beats breadth — don't hand a stranger 18 doors.

31 **Make the three working studios the product (Prompts, Canvas, Projects).**

MEDIUM

They're substantial and real. Lead with them.

32 **Demote the thin studios to "experimental."** QUICK

Honest labeling stops a stranger judging you by your weakest corner.

33 **Write an honest capability table: works / partial / aspirational.** QUICK

The most trustworthy marketing you can make.

34 **Make local-first + portability the headline — with enforcement behind it.**

MEDIUM

True and rare. Just make sure it's true on the shipped build.

35 **Ship an export/import that provably round-trips a whole workspace.** MEDIUM

"Portable by right" needs a button that proves it.

36 **Add a "your data never left this machine" indicator tied to real network behavior.** MEDIUM

Show the privacy, don't just claim it.

37 **Decide the legacy verse-studio: * key situation and document it.** QUICK

A known surprise is better than a hidden one.

38 **Get one real cold user through Noted; film where they get stuck.** MEDIUM

The stuck points are your roadmap.

39 **Hide anything that reads as hype until the core lands.** QUICK

"Attention without utility is not success" — your own line.

40 **Define "done for v0.1" as a short testable list; add no studios until met.** QUICK

A finish line stops breadth from eating depth.

05 · 41–50 The onboarding-AI tool (the cockpit)

Your "AI onboards the user, no narration" idea. Its first words are the whole first impression.

- 41 **Commit the uncommitted cockpit work now.** QUICK
It's the only at-risk thing in the Sandbox — a sponge left inside.
- 42 **Pressure-test onboarding cold — hand it to someone who knows nothing, film it.** MEDIUM
The cold-start run is the jaw-dropping demo, if it holds.
- 43 **Craft the onboarding prompt with the care you'd give a manifesto.** MEDIUM
If you say nothing, whatever it says *is* the pitch.
- 44 **Make the onboarding AI honest about limits.** QUICK
Let it show the unfinished parts — that's the trust story, live.
- 45 **Verify the key vault actually keeps keys out of child processes.** MEDIUM
It's claimed. Prove it, the way you proved the pop-out hole.
- 46 **Add a "what I can and can't do" screen before it acts.** QUICK
Consent and clarity before capability.
- 47 **Show which model answered (solo / failover / council), visibly.** QUICK
Transparency about routing is on-brand and reassuring.
- 48 **Prove the project-memory can't read outside its configured map.** MEDIUM
Bounded memory is a safety claim — test the bound.
- 49 **Decide: separate product, or Noted's Agent grown up? Name it.** QUICK
Clarity of what-it-is shapes everything downstream.
- 50 **Record a 60-second "just watch it onboard someone" clip.** MEDIUM
The core video asset — no voiceover, just the thing working.

06 · 51-60 Make the commons real (and keep the old words out)

The north star. Its biggest risk is quietly rebuilding what it seceded from.

51 Rename the router's "wallet module." QUICK

"Wallet" smuggles finance back in under STRICT NO SALE. Words carry logic.

52 Fill the "artistic column" of the isomorphism map — or admit it's empty. MEDIUM

Either result is progress; a blank column is the honest turtle-tell.

53 Put ONE real artist + ONE real artwork through an authorship flow. DEEP

The single act that gives the commons a real inhabitant instead of empty plumbing.

54 Build the minimal sign → anchor → attribute primitive end-to-end. DEEP

The smallest thing that actually proves authorship for that one work.

55 Test the social-capture failure mode on recognition with real people. DEEP

"Proof without power" relocates power to the crowd. See where it curdles.

56 Decide the permanence policy: can an artist disown early work? MEDIUM

Forever-provenance can chill the risk-taking art needs.

57 Write the commons as a "for" (beauty, merit), not just an "against" (banks). QUICK

Communities defined only by their enemy are fragile.

58 Choose the first tribe deliberately, and say why. QUICK

Crypto financializes reflexively; the art/sovereignty crowd may fit your values better.

59 Show the "NEX is wiped on launch" plan concretely. QUICK

Make the disposable-scaffolding promise checkable, not just stated.

60 Study one downstream-impact scenario in writing before building more infra. MEDIUM

Know what the commons does to an ecosystem before you scale it.

07 · 61-70 Research rigor & the thesis

You just shipped a falsifiable question about the whole project. Now use it well.

- 61 **Collect the multi-model thesis responses; synthesize the pattern.** MEDIUM
Report where they agree and diverge — never treat agreement as proof.
- 62 **Actually run the thesis's external-object test (T3).** DEEP
This is the move that turns "turtles" into "isomorphism," if anything does.
- 63 **Measure declared → enforced from git with a real script (T4).** MEDIUM
Replace the vibe with a number and a trend line.
- 64 **Publish the thesis result even if it says "turtles."** QUICK
The honest bad-news outcome is the one that builds the most trust.
- 65 **Turn the isomorphism map into a living document.** QUICK
Update it as each layer moves from declared to enforced.
- 66 **Define project "success" in one falsifiable sentence.** MEDIUM
If you can't say what winning is, you can't tell when you've won.
- 67 **Pre-register the next big experiment before running it.** QUICK
The 07-22 pivot did this well. Make it the norm.
- 68 **Keep a "claims we retracted" log.** QUICK
Retractions are the strongest trust signal you own.
- 69 **Ask each tested model for the single highest-value change; aggregate it.** QUICK
Cheap, and it surfaces blind spots you can't see from inside.
- 70 **Preserve model disagreement as data, not noise.** QUICK
Where they split is where the interesting truth usually hides.

08 · 71–80 Repo hygiene & process debt

The plumbing that keeps velocity from becoming the next whoopsie.

71 Prune stale worktrees; keep one-task-one-worktree. QUICK

The proliferation itself is a risk vector (and caused a near-miss today).

72 Triage the open-PR backlog on a schedule. QUICK

It grows faster than it drains; good work rots in draft.

73 Make a conscious call on PR #122. MEDIUM

The held security fix — merge it, split it, or close it, but decide.

74 Fix the promotion-origin CI check so it stops red-flagging every normal PR. QUICK

Constant false reds train everyone to ignore reds.

75 Update STATUS.json's stale reds. QUICK

The G-01 wording predates the pop-out finding — same declared-vs-real gap.

76 Close the long-open URGENT items that are actually done. QUICK

"URGENT" that's been done for days teaches people to ignore the word.

77 Publish a documented map of the ~15 similarly-named Lab folders. QUICK

Your new guards help; a map makes the sprawl legible.

78 Keep an always-current "start here for a fresh head" one-pager. QUICK

Every session begins warm instead of re-deriving the world.

79 Schedule a recurring "delete/quarantine what's dead" pass. QUICK

You did one on 07-24. Make it a monthly heartbeat.

80 Add a dashboard of what's authorized vs actually merged. MEDIUM

Keeps the merge-authorization discipline visible at a glance.

09 · 81–90 The stranger test, video & public voice

The moment the project meets someone who owes it nothing.

- 81 **Post the anchored Reddit stranger-test.** QUICK
It's ready and waiting. The anchor already proves it existed before posting.
- 82 **Decide what you want a stranger to do.** QUICK
Use / audit / believe / join — the answer changes the whole pitch.
- 83 **Lead public comms with the working thing, not the vision.** QUICK
Show Noted first; the commons is the horizon, not the handshake.
- 84 **Show the emergency stop on camera on purpose.** QUICK
"Here's a hole in my own thing, in plain sight" is the trust story only you can tell.
- 85 **Make the two artifacts public and link them from the post.** QUICK
The journey + the commons manpage do a lot of explaining for you.
- 86 **Record the "why" as you build.** QUICK
Your reasoning is more compelling than any finished feature.
- 87 **Write a 3-sentence version for someone with 30 seconds.** QUICK
If you can't compress it, it isn't clear yet.
- 88 **Tag every public claim with its evidence tier, even in marketing.** QUICK
Radical honesty in marketing is itself the marketing.
- 89 **Get one stranger's honest "I don't get it" — and fix the orientation.** MEDIUM
Usually the problem is the framing, not the tech.
- 90 **Publish the thesis result as a public artifact when it lands.** QUICK
Testing your own foundations in the open is the whole brand.

10 · 91–100 Continuity, sustainability & your own workflow

The project can't outlive the person running it if the person burns out.

91 Sort the credits situation so work doesn't stop mid-review. QUICK

It stopped today. A steady runway protects the honesty machinery.

92 Keep the memory/handoff system fed. QUICK

Every fresh head starts warm instead of cold.

93 Finish the "fix the hole" handoff note for the next seat. QUICK

We started it. It's the entry point for whoever picks up the emergency.

94 Define a sustainable pace. MEDIUM

The "fresh head" line suggests you feel the burn. Name a rhythm you can hold.

95 Keep a "you are here" doc for yourself, not just for seats. QUICK

Reduces the cost of every re-entry after an interruption.

96 Batch your decisions into deliberate sessions. QUICK

You make many merge/approve calls; batching cuts the load and the mistakes.

97 Protect the honesty machinery from your own velocity. QUICK

The 07-22 whoopsie came from speed, not carelessness. Build in friction where it counts.

98 Keep the plain-language gate — it's an accessibility feature, not just safety. QUICK

Explaining before acting protects you and anyone who ever joins.

99 Decide what "done" looks like for the whole project. DEEP

So it can end or arrive — not just recurse forever. The anti-turtle move.

100 Celebrate the real wins. QUICK

It's genuinely built and honestly documented. Momentum needs fuel — and you earned some.

One last thing. This is a menu written from inside the project by an AI that is part of the very loop it's assessing — so it is **not** independent, and it carries

status_authority: NONE. Take what pulls at you, ignore the rest, and come back to it with a fresh head. The one genuinely urgent item — the pop-out hole — is already on the Lab's front door. Everything else is yours to pace.

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